RVAcheapFLIGHTS

Richmond airfare: how fares are graded

Methodology brief · 255 graded fares out of RIC, Aug 17 – Oct 19, 2026

THE PROCESS

Every fare out of RIC goes through the same four steps. Nothing is hand-picked.

STEP 1
Watch
Fares out of Richmond arrive continuously and are graded five times a day, at 4am, 8am, noon, 4pm and 8pm Eastern. 255 fares graded across 26 airports in 64 days.

STEP 2
Compare
Each fare is measured against Google's own published typical price range for that exact trip — same route, same travel dates, captured at the same moment the fare is found. Not a flat dollar threshold.

STEP 3
Grade
How far the fare sits below that range sets a 1–10 grade. A nonstop earns a small bonus, two or more stops a small penalty.

STEP 4
Publish
A fare grading 7.0 or above is published; below that it is not. The threshold is fixed and applied the same way to every route, so no fare is promoted by hand.

WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

Why each route is judged against itself
$575 to Rome and $98 to Charleston are not comparable numbers. A fare is only meaningful against what that particular route normally costs, so every route is scored on its own terms.

Why Google's range, not an average of our own
The range is captured with each fare, so it already reflects that trip's travel dates, booking lead time and season. A single stored "normal price" per route goes stale and cannot tell a Thanksgiving week from a quiet one.

Why the bar sits below the middle
A fare in the middle of the typical range is an ordinary good price, not a find. The threshold is set deliberately toward the cheap end of the range so an ordinary price never gets called a deal.

DATASET COVERAGE

What is available for a reporter to inspect or audit from the current 64-day sample.

255	64	26	5×	84
fare observations	days tracked	airports across 23 cities	checks per day 4a 8a 12p 4p 8p ET	qualifying fares

REPORTER ACCESS Fare-level data is available on request — the exact fare, observed date, route, travel dates, airline, stops, grade, and the Google typical-price range captured with it. Every grade on the sheet can be recomputed from those columns.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWED, AUG 17 – OCT 19

Each route's average distance from its own typical price. Some of the strongest results are not where people expect them, and some short hops are consistently poor value out of Richmond.

BEST VALUE FROM RIC	VS TYPICAL
Charleston	51% below
Fort Myers	46% below
Nashville	35% below
Tampa	27% below
Las Vegas	25% below
Chicago (Midway)	21% below

WEAKEST VALUE FROM RIC	VS TYPICAL
Boston	34% above
Miami	25% above
New York (LaGuardia)	22% above
Fort Lauderdale	16% above
Newark	15% above
Montego Bay	12% above

HOW TO READ IT

These figures describe fares **observed** during a 64-day window. They do not prove year-round route behavior, company booking patterns, or whether another departure airport would have been cheaper — no comparison with Dulles, BWI or any other airport is made or implied. Fares reach us through fare alerts, which surface notably low prices, so the set is weighted toward the cheaper end of the market rather than being a representative sample of everything sold out of RIC. It describes prices **offered**, not tickets sold. Airfare moves constantly, so each price is accurate as of the date observed. Useful for identifying patterns worth investigating; not for claiming a permanent rule from a short sample.

Glenn Brown · RVA Cheap Flights · rvacheapflights.com · 804-210-9657 · fare-level data available on request